

Overcalls

Because of the Defensive element, the most important requirement for an Overcall is that you have a good suit, one that you'd like partner to lead. Keep in mind:

- a 5-card or longer suit with honor strength

- 9-16 points to overcall at the 1-level

- 11-16 points to overcall at the 2-level

Takeout Doubles

There are three kinds of Takeout Double:

- opening hand strength, no more than 2 of opponent's suit, at least 3 in all other suits
- strong Overcall type, at least 17 points and a good suit. Double, then bid the suit.
- strong Notrump type, 19+ points, stopper in their suit. Double, then bid notrump.

Responding to a Takeout Double

- 0-8 points, bid your best suit as cheaply as possible

- 9-11 points, jump in your best suit

- 12 or more points, cue-bid the opponent's suit

Board: 1
Dealer: **East**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥9

Board: 2
Dealer: **South**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♣5

Board: 3
Dealer: **East**
Contract: 4♥
Declarer: South
Lead: ♠K

Board: 4
Dealer: **South**
Contract: 4♠
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥Q

Board: 5
Dealer: **West**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦J

Board: 6
Dealer: **East**
Contract: 1♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♣9

Board 1

East Deals

None Vul

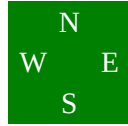
♠ Q 8 3
♥ 6 4 3
♦ 10 8 7 3
♣ 6 5 3

♠ J 7 6

♥ 10 5 2

♦ A J 9 4

♣ K 10 2



♠ K 5 2

♥ A 9 8

♦ K 5 2

♣ J 9 8 7

♠ A 10 9 4

♥ K Q J 7

♦ Q 6

♣ A Q 4

SOUTH has 18 points, a doubleton in the opponent's suit, and at least three cards in the unbid suits. This is an ideal hand for a Takeout Double.

NORTH has good strength in EAST's ♦ suit, probably two stoppers. He has 9 points and no 4-card suit of his own. This is the type of hand to respond 1NT.

SOUTH is happy to play Notrump now that she knows the ♦ s are covered, so she bids 3NT.

West	North	East	South
		1 ♦	Dbl
Pass	1NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			
3NT by North			
Lead: ♥9			

Board 2

South Deals

N-S Vul

♠ A K 9 6 4

♥ Q 5

♦ K 7 4

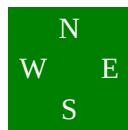
♣ J 10 7

♠ J 3 2

♥ 8 4 3

♦ Q 8 5 3

♣ K 6 2



♠ Q 8

♥ A J 9 2

♦ A J 6

♣ Q 9 8 3

♠ 10 7 5

♥ K 10 7 6

♦ 10 9 2

♣ A 5 4

WEST has an opening hand, 14 points and five ♠s. But SOUTH beat him to the punch, so he overcalls 1 ♠.

EAST also has 14 points, she doesn't care too much for ♠s, but she has an excellent stopper in ♥s. She jumps to 2NT, inviting WEST to bid game.

Since WEST has several points more than he might have had, and no 6-card ♠ suit to rebid, he happily bids 3NT.

*West**North**East**South*

1 ♠

Pass

2NT

1 ♥

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by East

Lead: ♣5

Board 3

East Deals

E-W Vul

♠ K Q 6 2

♥ A 8 2

♦ 9 4 2

♣ 9 3 2

♠ A 9 3

♥ J 10 5 3

♦ Q 5

♣ A K 8 6



♠ J 10 5 4

♥ 6 4

♦ J 10 7 6

♣ 10 7 5

♠ 8 7

♥ K Q 9 7

♦ A K 8 3

♣ Q J 4

SOUTH has 15 points and all the requirements for a Takeout Double of 1♠.

With 14 points of his own, NORTH knows his side needs to be in a game somewhere. He passes this information to SOUTH with a cue-bid of 2♠.

SOUTH gets the message and starts the hunt for a trump fit by bidding 3♥. That makes it easy for NORTH - he bids 4♥.

<i>West</i>	<i>North</i>	<i>East</i>	<i>South</i>
		1♠	Dbl
Pass	2♠	Pass	3♥
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			
4♥ by South			
Lead: ♠K			

Board 4

South Deals

Both Vul

♠ A Q J 6 4 2

♥ A 7

♦ J 7 2

♣ A 8

♠ 8 3

♥ Q J 10 4

♦ A 9 4

♣ K Q 10 5

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K 7 5

♥ 8 5 2

♦ K Q 3

♣ 9 7 6 2

♠ 10 9

♥ K 9 6 3

♦ 10 8 6 5

♣ J 4 3

There is only one reason that WEST should not overcall with 1♠. He is too strong. The maximum strength of an overcall is 16 points. Above that you should double.

So WEST doubles, and after EAST bids 2♣, WEST bids 2♠. This shows an overcall type hand, but with 17 or more points.

EAST has fine trump support and 8 points so she bids a confident 4♠.

*West**North**East**South*

1♥

Dbl

Pass

2♣

Pass

2♠

Pass

4♠

All Pass

4♠ by West

Lead: ♥Q

Board 5

West Deals

None Vul

♠ A 7 6
 ♥ Q 8 5
 ♦ A 9 3 2
 ♣ 10 9 4

♠ K 9 8 3

♥ 7 6

♦ K Q 5

♣ A J 7 6



♠ 10 5 4
 ♥ J 10 9 2
 ♦ J 10 8 6
 ♣ 5 3

♠ Q J 2

♥ A K 4 3

♦ 7 4

♣ K Q 8 2

NORTH has 13 points but has no bid over 1♦.
SOUTH can make a Takeout Double, so he does.

NORTH now cue-bids ♦ to show opening hand strength.

SOUTH shows his ♥ suit, NORTH doesn't like it.
NORTH shows her ♠ suit, SOUTH doesn't like it.
SOUTH shows his ♣ suit, NORTH likes it fine, but decides 3NT will be easier than 5♣.

West	North	East	South
1♦	Pass	Pass	Dbl
Pass	2♦	Pass	2♥
Pass	2♠	Pass	3♣
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			
3NT by North			
Lead: ♦ J			

Board 6

East Deals

None Vul

♠ Q 5 3
♥ 9 8 4
♦ 10 3 2
♣ A J 7 4

♠ 9 6

♥ Q 6 5

♦ J 7 5 4

♣ K 10 6 2



♠ K 8 2

♥ K J 10 2

♦ K Q 9

♣ Q 8 3

♠ A J 10 7 4

♥ A 7 3

♦ A 8 6

♣ 9 5

SOUTH would have had a great opening 1♠ bid. But when EAST opened 1♠ in front of him he was hornswaggled. He couldn't bid any other suit, he couldn't bid 1NT and he sure couldn't bid ♠s. So he must pass.

And so does everybody else pass.

*West**North**East**South*

1♠

All Pass

1♠ by East

Lead: ♣9